Newsletter: August 2026

Hello River Champions! The August newsletter is brought to you by Safina (our Student Lead) and Caroline (our new Volunteer Engagement Officer). Read on for an overview of recent training, the August drought, the latest volunteer survey, and more!

About Caroline – our new Volunteer Engagement Officer

After receiving my MSc in Biodiversity Conservation, I've worked in community engagement at the likes of the RSPB and local councils, but never in the West Midlands where I'm originally from!



I can't wait to bring my experience to this brilliant project and to meet some of you in the field soon!

Student Placement- Safina

During my internship, I've led river sampling sessions with 'Friends of' groups across South-West Birmingham; including Manor Farm Park, Ley Hill Park, Senneleys Park, and Kings Norton Nature Reserve! I have also been working on outreach for the student group as well as a bit of social media.

But don't worry! – even though my internship is coming to an end, I'm not going anywhere just yet – I will continue my role as student lead and attend the odd sampling session where I can (if you still want me of course…!)



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Recent Training

On the 21st July, Birmingham River Champions lead, Dr James White, led a training session at Cannon Hill Park with Friends of Rea Valley Stirchley as well as some of our wonderful student volunteers!

They found some bullhead (always a good sign as they are a protected species), some cased caddisflies and much more!

Thanks to all who attended!



Student Awards!

At UoB River Champions we have an awards scheme for volunteering! We have a bronze award for 5 sessions, silver for 10, and gold for 15 sessions! Here's an overview of our most recent awards:

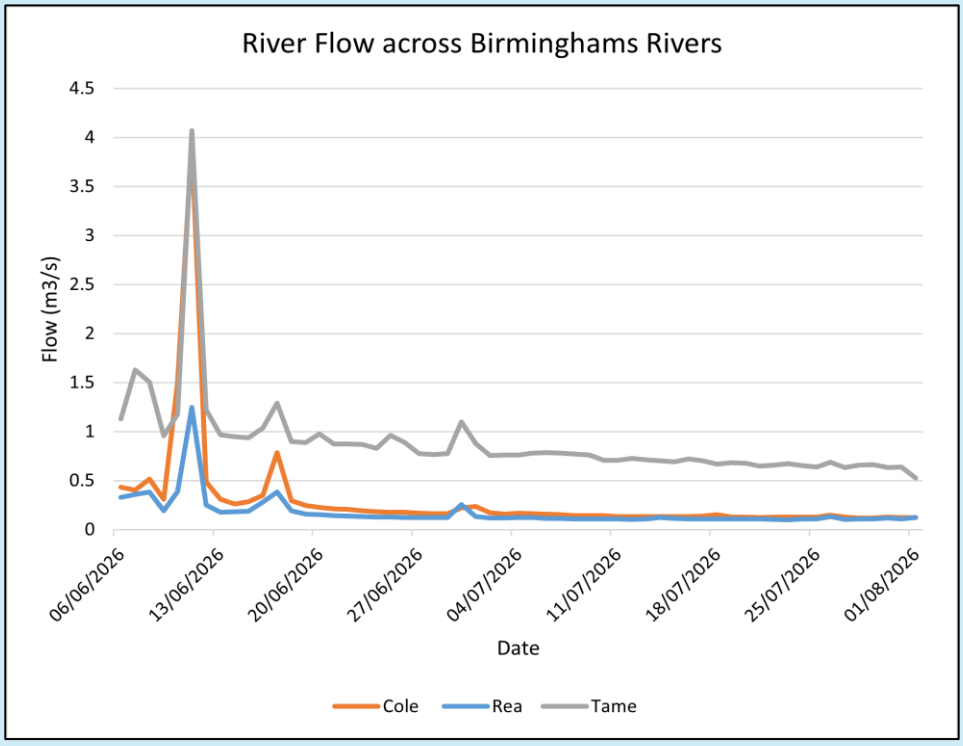
- **Bronze (5 sessions):** Lily Blackwell, Xue Chen, Eren Anderson, and Zhouyang Li
- **Gold (15 sessions):** Micah Beckford, and me (Safina)!



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Impacts of the Recent Drought

At the end of July, the Environment Agency declared that half of England, including the West Midlands, are in drought. The graph below shows the river flow at different sites in Birmingham using data from DEFRA's Hydrology data Explorer.



The graph shows flow, measured in meters cubed per second, peaking after the mid-June rain, but quickly dropping again. Latest data shows that flow is between 0.5m³/s-0.1m³/s across all sites.

Why do droughts matter for us?

Drought means there's far less water to dilute pollution, meaning that small changes in pollution have big impacts. Low flows also warm up and slow down the river flow, which reduces oxygen and strains the ecosystems.

With **another heatwave** predicted to be on the way, it's more important than ever to **keep up the monitoring!**

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Volunteer Survey

Occasionally, we like to check in on how river monitoring is going for you. A quick survey is one of the ways we like to do this!

The goal of this survey is to find out what parts of being a Birmingham River Champions you like, which parts you like less, and what we can improve going forward.

This survey is anonymous and should take about 5 minutes to complete.

Click HERE to fill out the survey, or email us for a PDF version via birminghamriverchampions@gmail.com



The Great UK WaterBlitz

On Friday 18th September to Monday 21st September, the Great Uk WaterBlitz is taking place!

Part of FreshWater Watch, the Great UK WaterBlitz asks people to test the quality of their local waterbody, including rivers, streams, lakes, ponds, canals and wetlands.

You can take part by visiting https://earthwatch.org.uk/greatukwaterblitz/

FREE WORKSHOP- Backyard Biomes: Managing & Conserving Garden Wildlife

Are you interested in making your garden more biodiverse? Why not attend a free workshop run by Dr Matthew Hill from Harper Adams University. See overleaf for more details.

For more details, email matthewhill@harper-adams.ac.uk

Harper Adams University

Backyard biomes: Managing & conserving garden wildlife



Dr Matthew Hill
Harper Adams University

About these workshops

This workshop will introduce wildlife gardening and outline the small changes that could be made to your garden to make it friendlier to biodiversity!

What we will cover

- Understanding the importance of garden for biodiversity.
- Introduction to wildlife gardening and the science that supports it.
- Garden managment to support urban biodiversity.
- Opportunity to contribute to scientific research/citizen science

Open to all. This session is ideal for anyone interested in garden wildlife, or getting started with wildlife surveying.

Refreshments and lunch will be provided.

Event Details:

Sat 5th Sept 2026,
10am-3pm,
B12 Urban Village Hall,
Balsall Heath, B12 9RJ

Book Here!

To book please scan the QR code or email matt, at matthewhill@harper-adams.ac.uk

FREE ENTRY!
(Limited to 20 people, ages 18+)